More and more of the resources needed to stay afloat came from the growing opium trade. SLORC's goal was to divide and rule the insurgents by making a pact with remnants of the BCP. By doing this, the tatmadaw was able to turn more of its attention and military might against the ethnic insurgents within the DAB. A final initiative that helped the tatmadaw was a forced relocation or ethnic cleansing policy implemented by the regime. The relocation policy convinced many ethnic groups to cut a deal with the government.

The cornerstone of the eradication efforts by the tatmadaw was the “four cuts” strategy. The regime attempted to cut food, funds, intelligence, and recruits from insurgent strongholds. During the peak of the four-cuts operation, over 2,500 villages were destroyed with over one million peasants being displaced. The rationale behind this brutal campaign was to make the insurgents deal with the government and lay down their arms.

Ultimately, the longest running and most threatening insurgency organization continued to be the Karen National Union (KNU). As a result of the divide-and-conquer strategy, the military was able to concentrate more troops against the Karens by 1994. After decades of holding its own against the military, the movement was devastated in December 1994, when a Buddhist Karen faction formed a separate organization called the Democratic Karen Buddhist Army (DKBA). The DKBA gave the tatmadaw vital intelligence information on the KNU, leading to the fall of the Karen stronghold of Manerplaw in late January 1995. The Karen insurgency maintains a thin presence in Myanmar, having little or no effect on government policy.

Tension still exists in border areas that continue to be out of the reach of the tatmadaw. Attempts to integrate ethnic insurgent forces into regular tatmadaw units are difficult. The loss of autonomy on the part of multiple groups including the Kachin will continue to plague the junta. As recently as September 2009, refugee influx from Kachin province into China created regional chaos as thousands of peasants fled across the border in search of sanctuary. This actually caused a temporary rift between the Myanmar and Chinese governments.

SOCIAL ILLS IN CONTEMPORARY MYANMAR